

3.2 New Features In Excel 2003

Excel 2003 hasn't improved much over previous versions, and the new features are few. Here's a list of the new features.

- m The ability to import and export XML data, and map the elements to cells in a worksheet. This feature is not available in all editions of Excel 2003 (see below for more)
- m A 'designated' list feature that identifies a worksheet list by outlining it with a blue border
- m Minor AutoFilter enhancements
- m The ability to synchronise worksheet scrolling to make it easier to compare two sheets
- m Fixes for some of the statistical functions
- m Integration with Microsoft SharePoint Services
- m Create 'Smart Documents' that utilise Smart Tags

XML Features

Unfortunately, not too many Excel users will find value in the new XML features. For example, say you have a worksheet database table and you want to export it to an XML file. You'd expect Excel 2003 to be able to handle such a task, but it can't. In order to export an arbitrary range of data to an XML file, you must first map the data to an 'XML schema file' (an XML schema provides a means for defining the structure, content and semantics of XML documents). And it's not possible to create such a file using Excel.

Also remember that the new XML features are available only in the Professional edition of Office.

Excel's new XML powers basically boil down to the ability to import data from a new source. When you open an XML file, you have the ability to map the elements to cells in a worksheet. For multi-element XML files, they come in as a list.

New List-Related Features

A common use for an Excel spreadsheet is to store a list of data. With Excel 2003, you can officially designate such a range list.